constant pressure in Pakistan due to army action in tribal areas, intelligence operations in urban centres and the US drone campaign in Waziristan. Resultantly, its command and control structure was severely bruised, especially after the military operation 'Zarb-e-Azb' was launched. Earlier, Osama bin Laden's death had already undermined its effectiveness.

Despite the confidence of the US and Pakistan in effective control over Pakistan's nukes 'some observers feared a radical takeover of a government that possesses a nuclear bomb, or proliferation by radical sympathisers within Pakistan's nuclear complex in case of a break-down of controls' (Kerr & Nikitin, 2011). But it was more of concern in 2007–8 when hugely unpopular General Musharraf's rule was at fag end and the democratic era was setting in. Transition seemed troublesome. Terrorism was also at its peak.

The US Chief of Staff Admiral Michael Mullen stated on 22 September 2008:

> To the best of my ability to understand it – and that is with some ability – the weapons there are secure. And that even in the change of government, the controls of those weapons have not changed. That said, they are their weapons. They're not my weapons. And there are limits to what I know. Certainly at a worst-case scenario with respect to Pakistan, I worry a great deal about those weapons falling into the hands of terrorists and either being proliferated or potentially used. And so, control of those, stability, stable control of those weapons is a key concern. And I think certainly the Pakistani leadership that I've spoken with on both the military and civilian side understand that (Kerr & Nikitin, 2011).

However, much later on, all significant US quarters, including President Obama, showed confidence in the safety of Pakistan's nukes.

President Obama said he felt 'confident that that nuclear arsenal will remain out of militant hands'. The then US Department of State spokesperson Mark Toner stated on 9 November 2011 that the US 'continue[s] to have confidence in the government of Pakistan that they both understand the threat to their nuclear arsenal, the varied threats to their nuclear arsenal, that they're taking appropriate steps to safeguard them' (Kerr & Nikitin, 2011).